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Tactical Pattern Recognition

Triggers, motifs, forcing geometry, and reliable pattern retrieval

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION	20

01. What Did The Last Move Change?



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Study the square a piece left as carefully as the square it reached.

PRIMARY PLAN

LANDING: Inspect new attacks and blocks.; ABSENCE: Inspect the vacated square and lines.; PROTECTION: Notice defenders that disappeared.; INTENT: Name the likely next idea.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They only developed' with 'Ask what became unguarded.'; Replace 'My plan still works' with 'Recheck the position after every move.'; Replace 'The threat is obvious' with 'Look for the quiet purpose too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

MEMORY RULE

Read the change first; make your plan second.

01. Decision Framework

What Did The Last Move Change?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	RESET: Forget your previous plan briefly.; LANDING: Scan attacks from the new square.; VACATED: Trace opened files and diagonals.; DEFENDERS: Recount critical protection.; RESPOND: Choose a move for the new position.
PIECE JOB	ARRIVAL: What does the moved piece attack from its new square?; DEPARTURE: What line or square did it stop protecting?; PURPOSE: What future idea became easier for the opponent?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	BOTH ENDS: Every move changes two squares.; LINES: Vacated squares often reveal tactics.; DEFENDERS: Protection can vanish silently.; INTENT: Predict the next move, not only this one.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

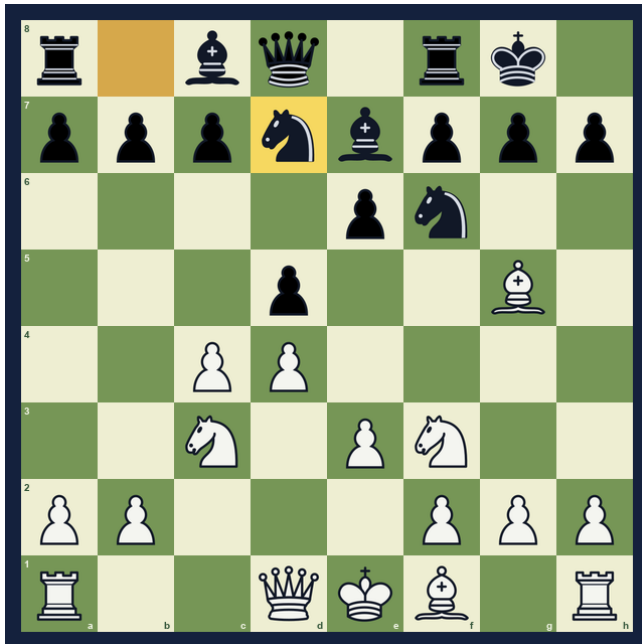
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Read the change first; make your plan second.

02. Loose Pieces Tell The Truth



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Identify what is loose, then ask which forcing move can exploit it.

PRIMARY PLAN

UNDEFENDED: Mark every piece defended zero times.; OVERLOADED: Find defenders tied to two duties.; ALIGNED: Trace kings, queens, and rooks on lines.; FORCING: Test checks, captures, and direct threats.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I cannot see a tactic' with 'First inventory tactical targets.'; Replace 'It is defended' with 'Ask whether the defender can move.'; Replace 'Only checks matter' with 'Use captures and double attacks too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Before hunting a tactic, find the pieces asking to be attacked.

02. Decision Framework

Loose Pieces Tell The Truth

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	INVENTORY: Find loose pieces for both sides.; COMPARE: Notice who has the weaker target.; GENERATE: Create forcing candidate moves.; CALCULATE: Follow the most forcing reply.; CLEANUP: Check what remains loose afterward.
PIECE JOB	UNDEFENDED: A piece with no defender is a standing invitation.; OVERLOADED: One defender may be doing two incompatible jobs.; ALIGNED: Pieces on one line invite pins, skewers, and discoveries.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	TARGETS: Combinations need something to attack.; DEFENDERS: Count their duties, not merely their number.; LINES: Geometry creates tactical possibilities.; BOTH SIDES: Your loose piece may refute your idea.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Before hunting a tactic, find the pieces asking to be attacked.

03. Compare The Two Kings



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Compare access, defenders, and attacking pieces before opening lines.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Count useful checking routes.; DEFENDERS: Count effective nearby defenders.; FORCES: Count attackers that can join quickly.; COST: Name what opening the position concedes.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Their king looks open' with 'Ask whether your pieces can reach it.'; Replace 'My king is castled' with 'Check lines and missing defenders.'; Replace 'I should sacrifice' with 'Count arriving forces before material.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

03. Decision Framework

Compare The Two Kings

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Inspect both kings, not only theirs.; ACCESS: Find checks that can actually arrive.; RECRUIT: Count pieces within two moves.; OPEN: Choose the safest useful line break.; RECHECK: Confirm your king survives the race.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Can checks reach the king without losing time?; DEFENDERS: Are nearby pieces able to protect critical squares?; FORCES: How many attackers can join before the position changes?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELATIVE: King safety is always a comparison.; ACCESS: An exposed king may still be unreachable.; NUMBERS: Attack with more pieces than the defense.; COST: Opening lines works in both directions.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

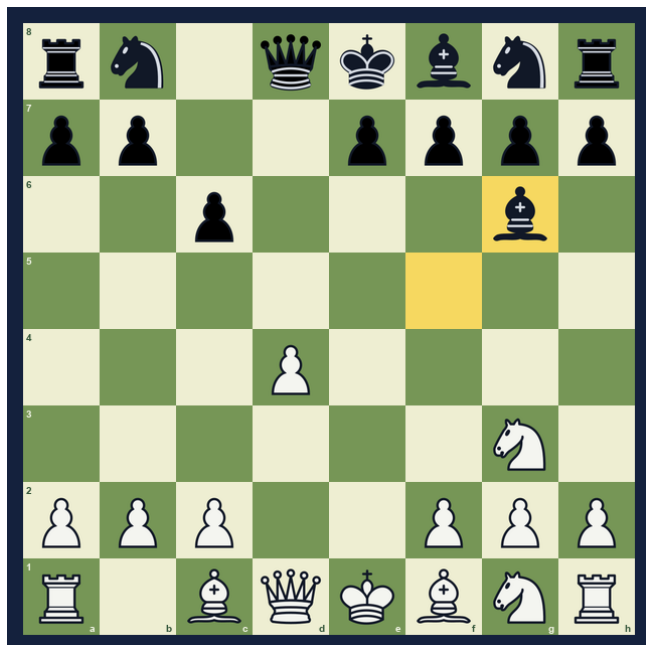
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

04. Count Attackers And Defenders



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Include hidden defenders, pinned pieces, and the value of the final occupant.

PRIMARY PLAN

NUMBER: Count legal attackers and defenders.; QUALITY: Remove pinned or immobile defenders.; ORDER: Start exchanges with the least valuable piece.; RESULT: Picture the final piece on the square.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is defended twice' with 'Check whether both defenders can move.'; Replace 'I win the first capture' with 'Follow the entire exchange sequence.'; Replace 'The numbers are equal' with 'Compare the value and order too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

When a square is crowded, replace intuition with an inventory.

04. Decision Framework

Count Attackers And Defenders

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MARK: Identify the contested square.; COUNT: List legal attackers and defenders.; FILTER: Remove pieces that are pinned.; ORDER: Run captures from lowest value upward.; RESULT: Evaluate the final material and position.
PIECE JOB	NUMBER: Start with how many legal captures each side has.; QUALITY: Pinned or overloaded defenders may not truly defend.; ORDER: The cheapest attacker often determines the exchange sequence.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	LEGAL: A pinned piece may not be a defender.; ORDER: Capture sequence changes the arithmetic.; FINAL: Evaluate the last position, not the first trade.; POSITION: Material gain can still lose activity or king safety.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When a square is crowded, replace intuition with an inventory.

05. Evaluate Before Choosing A Move



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Decide what the position needs before deciding how to provide it.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: Are there urgent threats to either king?;
 STRUCTURE: What will remain true after exchanges?;
 ACTIVITY: Whose pieces have better jobs?; PRIORITY: Which imbalance matters most now?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I see a move I like' with 'Give the position a diagnosis first.'; Replace 'Material is equal' with 'Compare activity, safety, and structure.'; Replace 'Everything matters' with 'Choose the most urgent imbalance.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

A good move is easier to find after you know what good means.

05. Decision Framework

Evaluate Before Choosing A Move

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Do not generate moves immediately.; SAFETY: Rule out tactical urgency.; COMPARE: Check structure and activity.; PRIORITY: Name one thing to improve or attack.; GENERATE: Choose moves that serve that priority.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: Check kings and immediate tactical instability first.; STRUCTURE: Find lasting strengths, weaknesses, and pawn breaks.; ACTIVITY: Compare which pieces are useful and which are restricted.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DIAGNOSE: Understand before prescribing a move.; COMPARE: Evaluation is always relative.; PRIORITY: One imbalance usually matters most.; PURPOSE: Candidate moves should solve a named problem.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A good move is easier to find after you know what good means.

06. Build A Candidate List



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Choose two or three moves from different categories before entering a line.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCING: Is there a sound forcing move?; IMPROVING: Which piece or pawn can improve?; PREVENTIVE: What opponent idea deserves attention?; CHOOSE: Keep the best two or three candidates.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate the first idea' with 'List candidates before analyzing lines.'; Replace 'Checks always come first' with 'Include only meaningful forcing moves.'; Replace 'Find ten possibilities' with 'Keep a small, contrasting shortlist.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

A short candidate list prevents both tunnel vision and wasted time.

06. Decision Framework

Build A Candidate List

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	DIAGNOSE: Name the position's priority.; GENERATE: Find forcing, improving, and preventive moves.; SHORTLIST: Keep no more than three.; CALCULATE: Test the most critical line first.; COMPARE: Return to the same final criteria.
PIECE JOB	FORCING: Include checks or captures only when they have a purpose.; IMPROVING: Find a move that improves your position without forcing.; PREVENTIVE: Consider a move that limits the opponent's main idea.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DIVERSE: Candidates should solve the problem differently.; SMALL: Two or three moves are usually enough.; FAIR: Calculate each serious candidate honestly.; COMPARE: Use one evaluation standard for every line.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A short candidate list prevents both tunnel vision and wasted time.

07. What Is The Opponent'S Idea?



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Find the opponent's strongest useful continuation, then decide whether it must be stopped.

PRIMARY PLAN

THREAT: What happens if I make a waiting move?;
IMPROVE: Which of their pieces wants a better square?;
URGENCY: Can the idea wait one move?; RESPONSE: Can my move answer it while improving?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They attacked something' with 'Ask what happens if you ignore it.'; Replace 'I must stop their idea' with 'Judge whether it is actually urgent.'; Replace 'Defense means retreat' with 'Prefer a useful move with two purposes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

07. Decision Framework

What Is The Opponent'S Idea?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	WAIT: Imagine passing your turn.; PREDICT: Name their strongest next move.; VALUE: Judge what that move would gain.; DECIDE: Stop, delay, or ignore it.; MULTIPURPOSE: Choose a response that also improves.
PIECE JOB	THREAT: A real threat changes material, king safety, or structure.; IMPROVEMENT: A quiet move may activate their worst piece.; URGENCY: Some ideas can be met after you improve your own position.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PREDICT: Name one serious opponent idea.; TEST: Use a waiting move to expose urgency.; SELECT: Not every idea deserves prevention.; IMPROVE: The best defense often serves your plan too.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

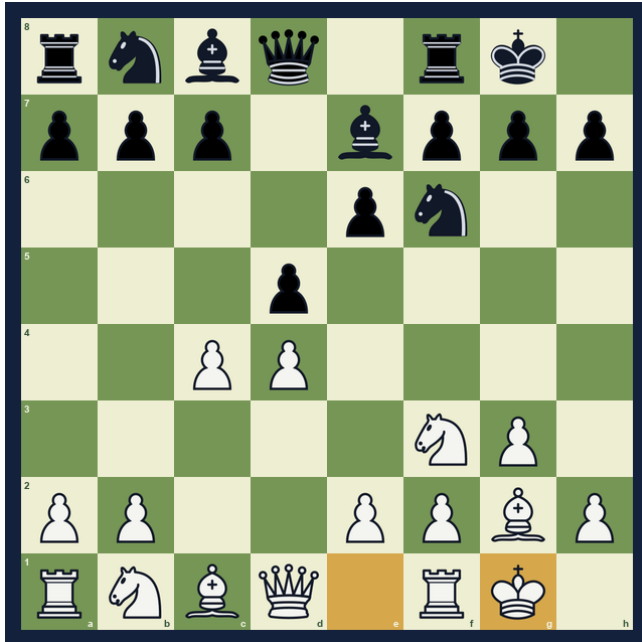
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

08. Prepare The Pawn Break



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Support the break, occupy the lines it will open, and calculate the opponent's best reaction.

PRIMARY PLAN

SUPPORT: Is the breaking pawn adequately supported?;
 PLACEMENT: Which pieces improve after lines open?;
 RESPONSES: Test capture, advance, and refusal.; OUTCOME:
 Which structure remains after each reply?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'The break is thematic' with 'Check whether the pieces are ready now.'; Replace 'They must capture' with 'Calculate advance and refusal too.'; Replace 'Open position is good' with 'Name which pieces actually improve.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

08. Decision Framework

Prepare The Pawn Break

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Identify the structural break.; PLACE: Move pieces onto future lines.; SUPPORT: Reinforce the advancing pawn.; TEST: Calculate all three responses.; BREAK: Play it when every reply helps.
PIECE JOB	SUPPORT: The advancing pawn needs enough protection or tactical justification.; PLACEMENT: Rooks and bishops should face the lines that will open.; RESPONSE: The opponent may capture, advance, or ignore the break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PERMANENT: Pawn breaks cannot be taken back.; PREPARE: Place pieces before opening lines.; RESPONSES: Capture is only one possible reply.; RESULT: Evaluate the resulting structure, not the push.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

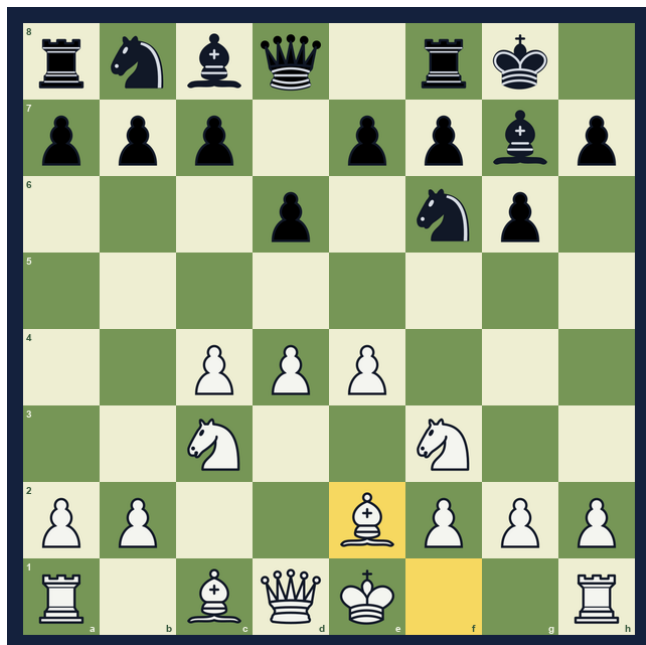
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

09. Control A Color Complex



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Enter through one square, then transfer to another faster than the defense can respond.

PRIMARY PLAN

PAWNS: Which color can their pawns no longer cover?

BISHOP: Is the matching bishop absent or restricted?

ENTRY: Which weak square can you reach first?; ROUTE:

Where can the piece transfer next?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Attack one weak square' with 'Use it as an entry into a network.'; Replace 'Trade bishops automatically' with 'Check which colors become undefended.'; Replace 'Push a pawn to chase' with 'Notice the new squares the push abandons.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

Do not merely occupy a weak square; use it to travel through the position.

09. Decision Framework

Control A Color Complex

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MAP: Mark the weak squares of one color.; REMOVE: Exchange the natural defender if useful.; ENTER: Occupy the safest access square.; TRANSFER: Move between related targets.; FIX: Prevent pawns from repairing the complex.
PIECE JOB	PAWNS: Pawn moves permanently abandon squares of the opposite color.; BISHOP: Trading a bishop can remove the natural color defender.; ROUTES: Queens and knights can move through several related weak squares.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NETWORK: Several weak squares support one another.; BISHOP: The missing color defender matters greatly.; ENTRY: One square can unlock the whole position.; PAWNS: Every pawn move gives up squares forever.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

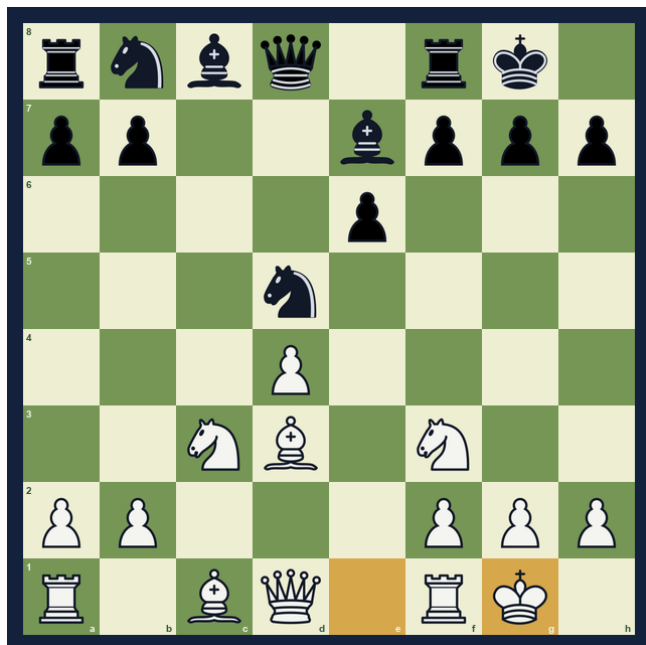
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not merely occupy a weak square; use it to travel through the position.

10. Exchange The Best Defender



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Identify the piece whose removal changes the opponent's entire defensive geometry.

PRIMARY PLAN

CONTROL: Which piece guards the key square?; JOBS: Which defender performs several duties?; REPLACE: What piece or pawn recaptures?; CHANGE: What becomes possible after removal?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Trade the nearest defender' with 'Find the piece with the most duties.'; Replace 'Give up bishop for knight' with 'Name the squares gained afterward.'; Replace 'Exchange and then decide' with 'Calculate the replacement before trading.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Remove the piece that holds the position together, then act before it is replaced.

10. Decision Framework

Exchange The Best Defender

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	TARGET: Name the square or king you want to reach.; TRACE: Find every meaningful defender.; RANK: Identify the defender with multiple jobs.; REMOVE: Choose a favorable exchange method.; ENTER: Use the newly available route immediately.
PIECE JOB	CONTROL: One piece may guard the critical entry square.; CONNECTION: A defender can link otherwise scattered pieces.; REPLACEMENT: The value of exchange depends on what replaces it.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUNCTION: Judge defenders by the jobs they perform.; OVERLOAD: Multiple duties reveal the key piece.; REPLACEMENT: Recapture may repair the defense.; TIMING: Exploit the removal before regrouping.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Remove the piece that holds the position together, then act before it is replaced.

11. Forcing Moves With Purpose



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Generate forcing moves, then reject the ones that improve the opponent's position.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCE: How many sensible replies remain?; RESULT: Where does the king or recapturing piece land?; PURPOSE: What does the move actually gain?; EXIT: Can you continue if the attack ends?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Always check first' with 'Test whether the check improves their king.'; Replace 'Capture because it is forcing' with 'Evaluate the recapture and resulting activity.'; Replace 'Keep the initiative' with 'Know where the forcing sequence ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

11. Decision Framework

Forcing Moves With Purpose

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	LIST: Notice checks, captures, and direct threats.; FILTER: Remove moves with an obvious good reply.; FOLLOW: Calculate the opponent's most resistant answer.; STOP: Reach a stable position.; EVALUATE: Judge the result without excitement.
PIECE JOB	REPLIES: A forcing move reduces the opponent's reasonable choices.; RESULT: The final position still decides whether the move is good.; PURPOSE: Every check or capture should serve a tactical or positional aim.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ATTENTION: Forcing moves deserve inspection, not obedience.; KING: A check may improve the king's location.; RECAPTURE: A capture can activate the opponent.; END: Know the position after the forcing moves stop.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

12. Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Continue until checks, captures, and immediate threats no longer control the next move.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCING: Does either side still have a forcing reply?; SAFETY: Are kings and major pieces stable?; EVALUATE: Who is better in the quiet position?; COMPARE: Apply the same stopping point to other lines.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I saw three moves' with 'Continue if the position is still forcing.'; Replace 'I won material' with 'Check whether king safety or recapture changes it.'; Replace 'The line feels good' with 'Name the final stable evaluation.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

12. Decision Framework

Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ENTER: Begin with the critical candidate.; FORCE: Follow the most demanding reply.; CLEAN: Resolve checks and captures.; STABILIZE: Reach a position with normal choices.; JUDGE: Evaluate material, safety, and activity.
PIECE JOB	FORCING: Unanswered forcing moves mean the line is unfinished.; STABILITY: Material, king safety, and loose pieces must be understandable.; EVALUATION: Only a quiet position can be compared reliably.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DEPTH: Count stability, not a fixed number of moves.; UNFINISHED: Forcing replies mean calculation must continue.; QUIET: Stable positions can be evaluated honestly.; CONSISTENT: Compare candidates at equivalent endpoints.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

13. Compare Final Positions



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Compare material, king safety, activity, structure, and practical difficulty at the endpoint.

PRIMARY PLAN

MATERIAL: What exactly remains on the board?; SAFETY: Whose king faces lasting danger?; ACTIVITY: Which pieces have useful work?; PRACTICAL: Which position is easier to handle?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'That line was forcing' with 'Judge its endpoint, not its drama.'; Replace 'The engine-like move wins a pawn' with 'Count activity and king safety too.'; Replace 'Both are equal' with 'Prefer the clearer practical plan.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

Choose the position you want to play, not the line you enjoyed calculating.

13. Decision Framework

Compare Final Positions

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FINISH: Reach a stable endpoint for line one.; LABEL: Give it a short evaluation.; REPEAT: Calculate line two to equal stability.; SCORE: Use the same four criteria.; CHOOSE: Select the best playable result.
PIECE JOB	MATERIAL: Count what remains after all forced exchanges.; QUALITY: Compare safety, activity, and durable weaknesses.; PRACTICALITY: Prefer positions whose plan is clear and errors are less costly.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ENDPOINT: Moves are only a route to a position.; SAME TEST: Evaluate every line with equal criteria.; WHOLE BOARD: A pawn gain may cost activity.; PLAYABLE: Practical clarity has genuine value.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

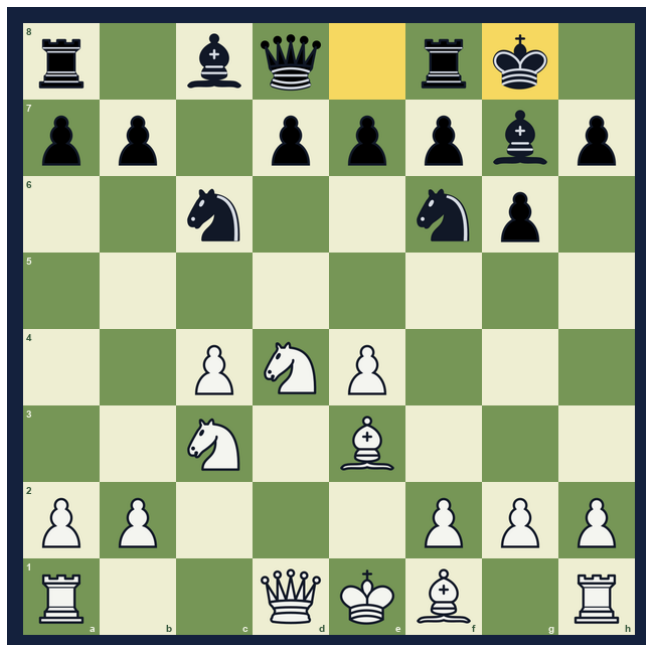
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Choose the position you want to play, not the line you enjoyed calculating.

14. Visualize With Landmarks



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Track captures, vacated lines, king locations, and newly loose pieces after each move.

PRIMARY PLAN

REMOVE: Which piece left the board?; LINES: What opened or closed?; ANCHORS: Where are both kings and queens now?; CHECK: What became loose after the change?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'See the whole board' with 'Track only the features that changed.'; Replace 'Replay from the beginning' with 'Update one landmark after each move.'; Replace 'Trust the mental picture' with 'Recount pieces before evaluating.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A clear calculation remembers what changed, not everything that stayed still.

14. Decision Framework

Visualize With Landmarks

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ANCHOR: Fix both kings in your mind.; MOVE: Relocate one piece clearly.; UPDATE: Remove captures and open lines.; SCAN: Check loose pieces in the new position.; REBUILD: Before deciding, picture the endpoint once.
PIECE JOB	REMOVALS: Captured pieces must disappear from future calculations.; LINES: A vacated square may open a file or diagonal.; ANCHORS: Kings, queens, and critical pawns orient the imagined board.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CHANGES: Visualization is an updating process.; REMOVALS: Do not let captured pieces defend as ghosts.; LINES: Vacated squares change geometry.; REBUILD: Confirm the final board before evaluation.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

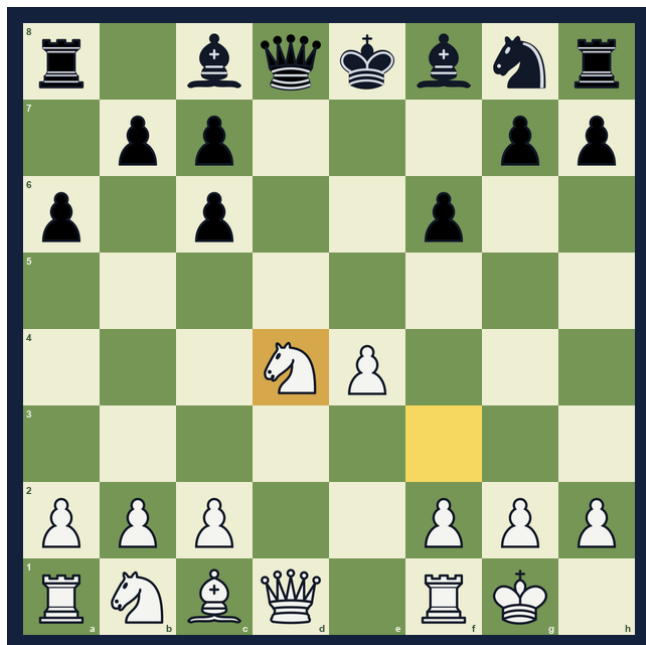
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A clear calculation remembers what changed, not everything that stayed still.

15. Recognize Tactical Triggers



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Loose pieces, exposed kings, overloaded defenders, and opening lines are invitations to search concretely.

PRIMARY PLAN

LOOSE: Did a piece lose a defender?; LINES: Did a file, rank, or diagonal open?; KING: Did shelter or checking access change?; OVERLOAD: Is one piece performing two jobs?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate when I feel danger' with 'Use concrete instability signals.'; Replace 'Tactics happen randomly' with 'Look for the structural trigger first.'; Replace 'Spend equal time each move' with 'Invest time when geometry changes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

Deep calculation should be triggered by evidence, not anxiety.

15. Decision Framework

Recognize Tactical Triggers

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NOTICE: Ask what the last move changed.; SCAN: Check loose pieces and king access.; TRACE: Follow newly opened lines.; GENERATE: Create forcing candidates.; INVEST: Calculate deeply only if a trigger exists.
PIECE JOB	LOOSE: Undefended and underdefended pieces create targets.; LINES: Newly opened files and diagonals change what can attack.; KING: Reduced shelter raises the value of forcing moves.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	SIGNALS: Instability tells you when to calculate.; CHANGE: The last move often creates the trigger.; GEOMETRY: Lines and overloaded pieces produce tactics.; TIME: Save clock time for positions that deserve it.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

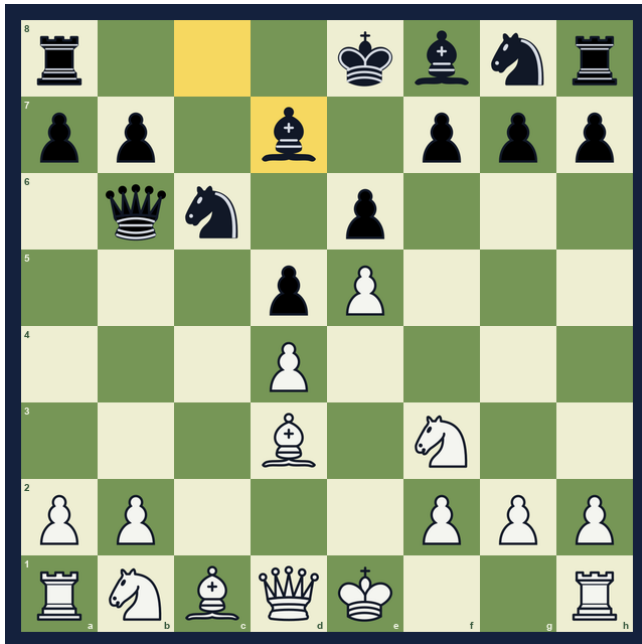
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Deep calculation should be triggered by evidence, not anxiety.

16. Look For The In-Between Move



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Delay the expected recapture only when the inserted move creates a lasting gain.

PRIMARY PLAN

PAUSE: Do not recapture automatically.; FORCE: Is there a check, capture, or major threat?; RETURN: Can you still complete the exchange later?; SAFETY: What forcing reply does the opponent have?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I must recapture' with 'Search for one forcing interruption.'; Replace 'Any check is useful' with 'Confirm the move creates lasting value.'; Replace 'I can recapture later' with 'Verify the original piece cannot escape.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

Before every automatic recapture, give yourself one chance to interrupt.

16. Decision Framework

Look For The In-Between Move

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Freeze before the expected recapture.; SEARCH: List forcing alternatives.; TEST: Use the opponent's strongest reply.; RETURN: Check that the original capture remains.; COMPARE: Choose the superior move order.
PIECE JOB	ASSUMPTION: Recapture feels mandatory even when it is not.; FORCING: A check or major threat may demand an immediate response.; RETURN: The original recapture must still be available afterward.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	AUTOMATIC: Expected recaptures create blind spots.; FORCE: Only serious interruptions deserve attention.; RETURN: Preserve the original tactical gain.; ORDER: Same moves in a different order can change everything.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Before every automatic recapture, give yourself one chance to interrupt.

17. Calculate Defensively



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Identify what makes the threat work, then block, trade, move, or counterattack that element.

PRIMARY PLAN

MECHANISM: What exactly makes the threat work?;
 OPTIONS: Can you move, block, trade, or counter?;
 RESISTANCE: Choose their strongest continuation.; END: Is the resulting position actually safe?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Save the attacked piece' with 'Break the mechanism behind the threat.'; Replace 'Defend the target again' with 'Consider trading the attacker instead.'; Replace 'Any move that survives' with 'Evaluate the position after the danger ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Good defense removes the threat's engine, not only its visible target.

17. Decision Framework

Calculate Defensively

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	DEFINE: State the threat precisely.; DISSECT: Find its necessary line or defender.; GENERATE: Use all four defensive methods.; TEST: Give the opponent maximum resistance.; STABILIZE: Choose the safest playable result.
PIECE JOB	MECHANISM: A threat depends on a line, defender, target, or move order.; OPTIONS: Defense includes moving, blocking, trading, and counterattacking.; RESIDUE: After surviving, avoid a position with a different fatal weakness.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	MECHANISM: Attack the reason the threat works.; FOUR METHODS: Move, block, trade, or counterattack.; BEST REPLY: Do not defend against a cooperative opponent.; AFTERWARD: Survival must lead to a playable position.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good defense removes the threat's engine, not only its visible target.

18. When To Calculate Deeply



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Calculate deeply when the move is forcing, irreversible, or changes the evaluation sharply.

PRIMARY PLAN

IRREVERSIBLE: Will the move permanently change structure or material?; UNSTABLE: Are forcing moves dominating?; CHOICES: Do candidates lead to different positions?; CLOCK: Can the decision justify the time cost?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate every candidate' with 'Screen moves before spending time.'; Replace 'Think longest when confused' with 'Look for critical features first.'; Replace 'Save all my time' with 'Invest it at irreversible crossroads.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

MEMORY RULE

Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

18. Decision Framework

When To Calculate Deeply

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SCREEN: Check for tactical or structural instability.; SHORTLIST: Keep two or three serious moves.; BUDGET: Choose a reasonable time limit.; CALCULATE: Follow the most critical response.; DECIDE: Stop when one line is clearly preferable.
PIECE JOB	IRREVERSIBLE: Pawn moves, sacrifices, and exchanges cannot be undone.; UNSTABLE: Exposed kings and loose pieces make evaluation volatile.; CHOICE: Critical positions offer several plausible but different paths.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CRITICAL: Some moves deserve far more time than others.; IRREVERSIBLE: Permanent changes require care.; SCREEN: Do not calculate bad candidates deeply.; STOP: A clear preference is enough to decide.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

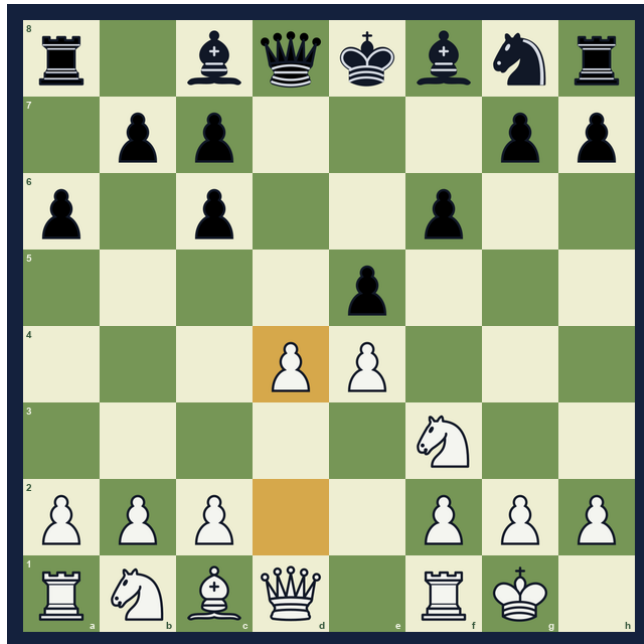
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

19. Use Your Clock Like A Budget



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

Use fast routines for familiar positions and deliberate budgets for irreversible choices.

PRIMARY PLAN

BASELINE: What is your normal move budget?; **INVEST:** Is this position truly critical?; **RESERVE:** How much time must remain later?; **COMMIT:** When the budget ends, choose safely.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'More time finds truth' with 'Stop when one move is clearly adequate.'; Replace 'Think deeply in every position' with 'Use routines for ordinary decisions.'; Replace 'I will play fast later' with 'Protect a reserve before trouble begins.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

19. Decision Framework

Use Your Clock Like A Budget

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	GLANCE: Check clock and game phase.; CLASSIFY: Ordinary or critical position?; BUDGET: Set a mental stopping point.; DECIDE: Use the best evidence available.; RESET: Begin the next move fresh.
PIECE JOB	BASELINE: Ordinary moves need a modest default time.; INVESTMENT: Critical positions deserve a deliberate larger spend.; RESERVE: Keep enough time to make safe decisions near the end.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RESOURCE: Time is part of the position.; UNEQUAL: Critical moves deserve unequal spending.; RESERVE: Late safety requires saved time.; ENOUGH: A sound move on time beats perfection too late.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

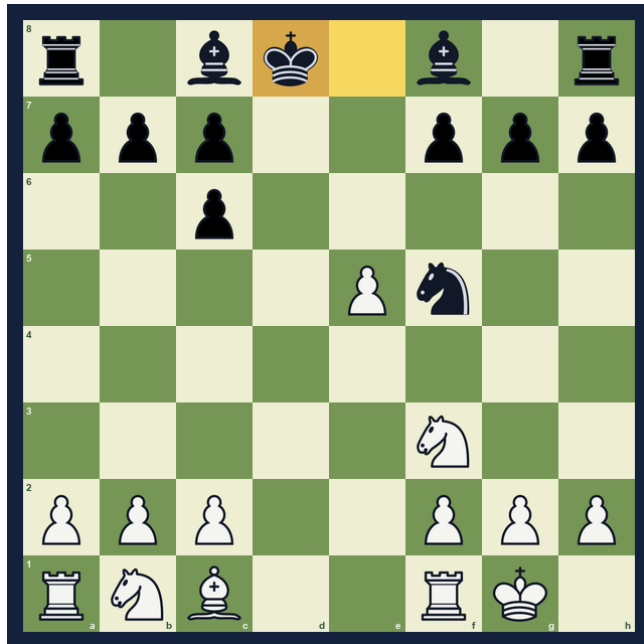
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

20. Train Patterns, Not Answers



TACTICAL PATTERN RECOGNITION

READ THE POSITION

After solving, name what made the tactic or plan possible and what would remove it.

PRIMARY PLAN

TRIGGER: What feature first called for the move?; MECHANISM: Why did the move work?; VARIATION: What change would make it fail?; RECALL: Can you explain it tomorrow without the board?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Memorize the solution' with 'Name the cue that should trigger it.'; Replace 'Solve more positions' with 'Review fewer positions more deeply.'; Replace 'The answer makes sense' with 'Change one feature and test the idea.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

A pattern is not an answer you remember; it is a situation you recognize.

20. Decision Framework

Train Patterns, Not Answers

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SOLVE: Find the move without hints.; NAME: State the trigger and mechanism.; CHANGE: Alter one defender, line, or square.; RETEST: Decide whether the idea still works.; RECALL: Review the lesson the next day.
PIECE JOB	TRIGGER: A loose piece, open line, or weak square starts recognition.; MECHANISM: The idea works through a pin, overload, route, or break.; VARIATION: Changing one feature tests whether you truly understand.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CUE: Recognition begins with a visible feature.; WHY: Mechanisms transfer better than moves.; CONTRAST: A near-miss teaches the boundary.; SPACING: Delayed recall turns insight into memory.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A pattern is not an answer you remember; it is a situation you recognize.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.